

28. Global boundary spanners

Global boundary spanners can be defined as individuals who are recognized by members of both their own in-group and/or relevant out-groups for their long-term commitment to engage in and facilitate significant interactions between the groups, in order to integrate activities across cultural, institutional and/or organizational contexts (Barner-Rasmussen, Ehrnrooth, Koveshnikov, & Mäkelä, 2014; Roberts & Beamish, 2017; Schotter, Mudambi, Doz, & Gaur, 2017; Mäkelä, Barner-Rasmussen, Ehrnrooth, & Koveshnikov, 2019).

Interest in how the organization is linked to its environment through individuals acting at the boundary is an offshoot of the broader organizational question of how organizational boundaries are maintained and managed (e.g., March & Simon, 1958; Katz & Kahn, 1966). Aldrich and Herker (1977) were early adopters of the label “boundary spanning” to denote these actions, arguing that boundary-spanning individuals performed two classes of functions: information processing and representation towards external parties. Their research focused on the role of foundation spanners as gatekeepers.

Tushman and Scanlan (1981a, 1981b) broadened the gatekeeping perspective by highlighting that boundary spanners also play an important communication role. Building on empirical research in the R&D laboratory context, they argued that being engaged in external communication alone was a necessary but insufficient condition; to qualify as boundary spanners, individuals had to span across internal or external communication boundaries created by different *language* schemes and conceptual frameworks (Tushman & Scanlan, 1981b). Foreshadowing later research, these authors also questioned whether and to what extent boundary spanning is linked to formal status, and instead argued for perceived technical competence and communicative abilities as key drivers of boundary spanning.

Research on boundary spanners, like other research on individuals in MNEs (see the entry *expatriation*), subsequently bifurcated into two distinct streams. One stream focuses on a closely intertwined set of functions

such as knowledge transfer (e.g., Kogut & Zander, 1993), *coordination* and *control* (e.g., Harzing, 2001). The other focuses on “the role and characteristics of specific individuals as boundary spanners and their effectiveness in operating across complex inter- and intra-organizational, socio-cultural and geographic boundaries” (Schotter et al., 2017: 404). Boundaries are here understood as organizational barriers characterized by difference (without which there is no boundary), dependence (without which the boundary is not meaningful) and novelty (which creates friction through unfamiliarity) (Carlile, 2002, 2004; Mäkelä et al., 2019). Our definition of global boundary spanners builds on the latter body of literature, which in the context of international strategic management grows out of a longstanding interest in inter-unit knowledge sharing as a condition for sustained competitive advantage of multinational enterprises (MNEs) (Bartlett & Ghoshal, 1987; Kogut & Zander, 1993). In the 2000s, this originally organizational-level work expanded to the individual level with the insights that most everyday inter-unit interactions take place at the interpersonal level (Argote & Ingram, 2000), and that these individual-level micro-foundations play an important part in organizational-level outcomes (Foss & Pedersen, 2004; Barney & Felin, 2013).

Empirical work in this vein has subsequently specified different roles that individual boundary spanners perform in the MNE context. In the context of HQ–subsidiary knowledge sharing, Barner-Rasmussen et al. (2014) identified *exchanging*, *linking*, *facilitating*, and *intervening* as boundary-spanning roles. They found cultural and language skills to be important determinants of the extent to which individuals perform the more demanding facilitating and intervening roles. Similarly, Birkinshaw, Ambos and Bouquet (2017) identified four boundary-spanning roles that MNE HQ managers engage in: *spearheading* and *facilitating* connections across boundaries, and *reconciling* and *lubricating* differences in worldviews. Söderberg and Romani (2017), in turn, identified three generic boundary-spanning roles of vendor managers in the context of global IT development projects: managing boundaries through *buffering* and *reflecting*, forging common ground by *connecting* and *mobilizing*, and

developing new frontiers through *weaving* and *transforming*.

Recent research suggests that global boundary spanners recognized by both in- and out-group members are few and far between (Mäkelä et al., 2019), and questions the relevance of formal boundary-spanning positions. Successful boundary spanners seem to be distributed across different organizational levels and job roles, and often lack formal responsibility for boundary spanning (Yagi & Kleinberg, 2011). Boundary-spanning ability appears to be driven by personal skills (e.g., expertise or cultural/linguistic skills) or motivation, persistence and willingness (Barner-Rasmussen et al., 2014; Levina & Vaast, 2005; Roberts & Beamish, 2017) rather than job role or structural network position (e.g., Kostova & Roth, 2003; Richter et al., 2006). All in all, it seems that boundary spanning can be formalized only to a certain extent (Schotter & Beamish, 2011), and that individuals formally appointed to boundary-spanning positions are not always the most effective in performing these tasks (Levina & Vaast, 2005). The opportunities for boundary spanning also seem to be powerfully shaped by the organizational context, such as the MNE's internal interaction structure (many contact points between units also provide opportunities for more boundary spanning to occur; Mäkelä et al., 2019), and by power issues such as those related to gender, race and class (Collien, 2021), which may boost or hamper boundary-spanning efforts.

In terms of future research, recent calls have emphasized the need to study boundary spanning at the activity level; that is, in terms of the specific actions taken by boundary-spanning individuals, and their consequences (Birkinshaw et al., 2017; Söderberg & Romani, 2017; see also Schotter et al., 2017) to enrich and deepen the insights gleaned from extant interview-based and cross-sectional research. Recent research has also differentiated between potential boundary spanners, i.e., individuals who are involved in inter-unit interactions, and recognized boundary spanners who are experienced by relevant others on both sides of the boundary to actually facilitate and positively impact intergroup transactions and relations (Mäkelä et al., 2019). These findings suggest that boundary-spanning actions must be eval-

uated by others on both sides of the boundary. Are the actions of the boundary-spanning individuals actually experienced as helpful and beneficial by relevant others or not? This focus on recognized boundary spanners emphasizes aspects of identification and learning. How do boundary spanners themselves identify? How are they identified by others (Kane & Levina, 2017)? What role do they play in providing cognitive, relational and material support for learning about others' practices (Roberts & Beamish, 2017)?

All in all, assuming that business activities and *global value chains* continue to evolve towards increasing collaboration – even between competitors – as the external environment grows more turbulent, the importance of boundary spanning will also increase. To date, accumulated knowledge about global boundary spanners suggests that their interpersonal-level actions and interactions play an important role in helping MNEs overcome the barriers inherent in geographical, cultural and linguistic fragmentation, both internally and in relation to external partners.

WILHELM BARNER-RASMUSSEN AND
KRISTIINA MÄKELÄ

References

- Aldrich, H. E. & Herker, D. 1977. Boundary spanning roles and organization structure. *Academy of Management Review*, 2(2): 217–230.
- Argote, L., & Ingram, P. 2000. Knowledge transfer: A basis for competitive advantage in firms. *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes*, 82(1): 150–169.
- Barner-Rasmussen, W., Ehrnrooth, M., Koveshnikov, A., & Mäkelä, K. 2014. Cultural and language skills as resources for boundary spanning within the MNC. *Journal of International Business Studies*, 45(7): 886–905.
- Barney, J., & Felin, T. 2013. What are microfoundations? *Academy of Management Perspectives*, 27(2): 138–155.
- Bartlett, C. A., & Ghoshal, S. 1987. Managing across borders: New strategic requirements. *Sloan Management Review*, Summer: 7–17.
- Birkinshaw, J., Ambos, T. C., & Bouquet, C. 2017. Boundary spanning activities of corporate HQ executives: Insights from a longitudinal study. *Journal of Management Studies*, 54(4): 422–454.
- Carlile, P. R. 2002. A pragmatic view of knowledge and boundaries: Boundary objects in new

- product development. *Organization Science*, 13(4): 442–455.
- Carlile, P. R. 2004. Transferring, translating, and transforming: An integrative framework for managing knowledge across boundaries. *Organization Science*, 15(5): 555–568.
- Collien, I. 2021. Concepts of power in boundary spanning research: A review and research agenda. *International Journal of Management Reviews*, 23: 443–465.
- Foss, N., & Pedersen, T. 2004. Organizing knowledge processes in the multinational corporation: An introduction. *Journal of International Business Studies*, 35(5): 340–349.
- Harzing, A.-W. 2001. Of bears, bumble-bees, and spiders: The role of expatriates in controlling foreign subsidiaries. *Journal of World Business*, 36(4): 366–379.
- Kane, A. A., & Levina, N. 2017. Am I still one of them? Bicultural immigrant managers navigating social identity threats when spanning global boundaries. *Journal of Management Studies*, 54(4): 540–577.
- Katz, D., & Kahn, R. L. 1966. *The Social Psychology of Organizations*. John Wiley & Sons, New York.
- Kogut, B., & Zander, U. 1993. Knowledge of the firm and the evolutionary theory of the multinational corporation. *Journal of International Business Studies*, 24(4): 625–645.
- Kostova, T., & Roth, K. 2003. Social capital in multinational corporations and a micro-macro model of its formation. *Academy of Management Review*, 28(2): 297–317.
- Levina, N., & Vaast, E. 2005. The emergence of boundary spanning competence in practice, implications for implementation and use of information systems. *MIS Quarterly*, 335–363.
- Mäkelä, K., Barner-Rasmussen, W., Ehrnrooth, M., & Kovesnikov, A. 2019. Potential and recognized boundary spanners in multinational corporations. *Journal of World Business*, 54(4): 335–349.
- March, J. G., & Simon, H. A. 1958. *Organizations*. John Wiley & Sons, New York.
- Richter, A. W., West, M. A., van Dick, R., & Dawson, J. F. 2006. Boundary spanners' identification, intergroup contact, and effective intergroup relations. *Academy of Management Journal*, 49(6): 1252–1269.
- Roberts, M. J., & Beamish, P.W. 2017. The scaffolding activities of international returnee executives: A learning-based perspective of global boundary spanning. *Journal of Management Studies*, 54(4): 511–539.
- Schotter, A., & Beamish, P. W. 2011. Performance effects of MNC headquarters–subsidiary conflict and the role of boundary spanners: The case of headquarter initiative rejection. *Journal of International Management*, 17(3): 243–259.
- Schotter, A. P., Mudambi, R., Doz, Y. L., & Gaur, A. 2017. Boundary spanning in global organizations. *Journal of Management Studies*, 54(4): 403–421.
- Söderberg, A.-M., & Romani, L. 2017. Boundary spanners in global partnerships: A case study of an Indian vendor's collaboration with Western clients. *Group & Organization Management*, 42(2): 237–278.
- Tushman, M. L., & Scanlan, T. J. 1981a. Boundary spanning individuals: Their role in information transfer and their antecedents. *Academy of Management Journal*, 24(2): 289–305.
- Tushman, M. L., & Scanlan, T. J. 1981b. Characteristics and external orientations of boundary spanning individuals. *Academy of Management Journal*, 24(1): 83–98.
- Yagi, N., & Kleinberg, J. 2011. Boundary work: An interpretive ethnographic perspective on negotiating and leveraging cross-cultural identity. *Journal of International Business Studies*, 42(5): 629–653.